

Impactful: In just over seven years since its inception, SMVDSB — with its training facility located in Katra, Jammu — has established itself as a prominent player in Indian sports. RITU RAJ KONWAR

can be admitted. There is no bar for students from outside the region. All we are looking for is how good the athlete is.

A key component in a residential academy is the presence of experienced coaches. How did you manage to recruit them to a relatively new facility in an unexplored terrain?

It was a difficult process in the beginning. We started getting coaches almost a year after we began. We spent a lot of time identifying the right talent and convincing them that this is a good place. We have a lot of avenues for growth of coaches inside the organisation. And they have total freedom to train their athletes.

We are also flexible in our recruitment. People who excel in a sport are recruited as coaches. For example, Rakesh joined as a player and after performing consistently for four years and winning medals, has now been recruited as an assistant coach. So, that is a progression path.

Like every training academy, success at the regional and national levels is critical. How do you look at your organisation's growth and prospects?

Rakesh was the first stepping stone. Sheetal has built on it and now a lot of girls in the region have been inspired by her. We have high hopes for both of them from the Paris Olympics. Sarika is a para-archer from Haryana, who, we are hoping, will bring in a medal from Paris. Pragya and Raveena are our brightest prospects in shooting. We are expecting medals from them at the National Games.

Are you planning to expand to other disciplines and was it a conscious decision to stick to individual sports?

As of now, the plan is to focus on



these four. We are trying to achieve excellence in these rather than diversify into a lot of other activities. If we do that, we might be spread out too thin. This again depends on the ecosystem. If a promising talent comes up in another sport from the region, the board will be open to broadening our approach.

It was not a conscious decision not to invest in team sports. Once we began, we understood it was easier to deal with individual sports. In future, we could look at team sports.

What do you feel is the defining philosophy of SMVDSB?

We are looking to create an environment of excellence. We have around 150 athletes, who are training every day. And based on their performance we are also providing scholarships to some of the best performing athletes. This is to motivate them. Our ultimate ambition is to harness the potential of as many young athletes as possible. Because, once they reach a particular level, we do not need to support them. Take Sheetal as an example. She is being backed by IOC and she is guaranteed a job. We want to create options for our players so that they can get ahead in life.